When Memories Get Lost at Sea

A Child's Story About EMDR

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This book supports, but is not, therapy. EMDR should be done with a trained, licensed EMDR therapist.

For every brave kid who has weathered a storm,
and for the grown-ups who stay beside them
until they find their way back home.



Part One: My Harbor and the Memory Boat

Every day, new things happen. Each new happening becomes a memory. Inside me, there is a busy little harbor where all those memories come in like boats.



Deep in that harbor lives my Captain—my Biggest Self. This special part of me guides every boat to where it belongs and never, ever leaves me.



Its light glows warm and steady: calm, kind, brave, curious, and wise. Every kid has a Captain—grown-ups do too. Sometimes storms hide that light, but it never goes out.





Meet Tuff

Up in the lookout, high above the waves, lives Tuff, my Captain's helper. He has one big job: keeping me safe. Tuff watches. Tuff listens. Day and night, he keeps a big brass bell close, ready to ring at the first sign of danger.

Boats Come Home

All day long, memory boats come sailing in: lost-tooth boats, first-day-of-school boats, and silly-joke boats. Each one gets unloaded and finds its home. Then my brain knows that memory is finished. I can visit it anytime, and it stays calm and quiet.



My Happy-Sad Boat

One of my favorite boats holds a memory of a special trip with my grandma, right before she died. That boat is tied up neat, and I can visit it when I please.



Sometimes it makes me sad, because I miss her. I feel grateful, too, for the time she was around. Even a boat full of sad feelings and happy feelings can rest peacefully at the dock where it lives.





The Memory Boat Lost at Sea

One day, something really scary happened to me. It was the kind of thing no kid should ever go through. My heart pounded. Everything felt wrong. I couldn't make it stop. I felt bad and thought it was my fault.

It felt like a giant storm inside me. It was so big and so fast that my brain didn't get to finish putting that memory away. My memory boat never made it back to the dock. It got stuck out at sea.



Sometimes more than one memory boat ends up lost, especially when storms come *again and again*.



Still Lost

Even after it was over, I felt bad inside for days and days. I thought something was wrong with me. My memory boat was lost out there somewhere. And Tuff kept watch from the lookout, day and night, never getting to rest.



Triggers

Sometimes a small thing, like a loud door slam, brought the stormy feelings back. Tuff got mixed up. He couldn't tell the difference between then and now. He thought, "AHH! The storm! It's happening again! I must keep us safe!"



So he rang the alarm bell. Ding! Ding! Ding! My body reacted as if the danger were back. That's called a trigger. It wasn't my fault, and it wasn't Tuff's either. He wasn't trying to scare me—he was trying to protect me.



Signs of a Stuck Memory Boat

While my memory boat was stuck, I had bad dreams at night. A tummy in knots. A jumpy body that couldn't sit still. Feelings that came fast and went BOOM.



Sometimes the scary day replayed in my head, like a movie stuck on the bad parts. I hid from reminders, felt littler than I was, and found it hard to focus. These were signs Tuff was working hard, not that I was bad.



Part Two: Getting My Harbor Ready

What Is EMDR?

My grown-ups found me a special helper called an EMDR helper. EMDR stands for Eye Movement Desensitization and Reprocessing. That's a big, long name! It just means EMDR helps my brain finish putting stuck memories away, so they can rest at the dock.



Getting Ready

Before we set out to bring the lost memory boat home, my EMDR helper and I got my harbor ready. We practiced calm tools together, so my Captain felt strong and steady inside. We went nice and slow, and I always got a say.



Drop My Anchor

When I got wobbly, I learned to drop my anchor. I pressed my feet into the floor and let the ground hold me up. I named five things I could see and told myself, “I’m here, in this room, today.” That made me feel stronger.



My Safe Harbor

With my EMDR helper, I found a calm, safe place I could imagine anytime. There the water was still and quiet, and Tuff could rest a little too.

And my Captain's light glowed a little brighter.



My Stop Signal

My EMDR helper and I picked a stop signal, like a hand held up or a special word. Whenever I showed it, we stopped, and I wasn't in trouble. My helper checked in, and we decided together what I needed. I was the boss of my harbor.



My Sea Chest

On my dock, I pictured a strong sea chest. When the memory boat felt too big, I tucked the stormy feelings inside. Click, clack, locked up tight. They waited there safely until my EMDR helper and I were ready.

And my Captain's light glowed a little brighter.



My Crew of Helpers

I gathered a crew of helpers in my mind. Some were cozy and caring, some were strong protectors, and some were wise. They could be real or pretend: a grandma, a big brown bear, or a brave best friend. With my crew close, Tuff felt less alone.



Light Stream

My Captain could also shine a warm, healing light, like a lighthouse beam. It flowed into any spot in my body that felt tight or scared. The beam could be any color I liked.



Butterfly Hug

Then I learned the Butterfly Hug. I crossed my arms, rested my hands on my shoulders, and tapped left, right, left, right. Flutter, flutter, soft and slow, like gentle butterfly wings. I took deep breaths. My body calmed, and so did Tuff.

And my Captain's light glowed a little brighter.



Part Three: Bringing the Boat Home

EMDR Helps the Boat Come In

My EMDR helper stayed right beside me while I thought about a little piece of that big scary day. My eyes followed my helper's hand, or I held small dark green buzzers that tapped back and forth.



Left, right, left, right. Little by little, bit by bit, the lost memory boat sailed closer to the dock, where it could finally be sorted through.



Riding the Waves

As the boat came in, big feelings rose and fell like waves. Up and down they rolled. I noticed them, breathed, and rode them out, bobbing along like a cork on the water. When I needed a break, I showed my stop signal and we paused, because my inner Captain was in charge.



The Memory Boat Comes Home

Slowly, we brought my memory boat in. It took lots of visits, but that was okay. One by one, we lifted off the scared feelings and heavy thoughts it had carried out at sea, like “It was my fault.” I didn’t have to hold them anymore.



In their place, I chose new, true thoughts, like “I did my best” and “I’m strong.” At last, my memory boat came home to the place where it belonged.



Anchored Inside

These days, I still remember what happened on that day. But when I visit that memory boat, it feels like something from back then, not right now. The storm is quiet, and my brain knows it's over.



Thank you, Tuff, for keeping watch through every wind and wave. You can rest now, my cozy lookout. The bell is silent. The water is calm. My Captain's light shines warm and bright, and I am safe, anchored inside.




Life can be tuff, but so are you.

Activity Pages

These four pages can be laminated for dry-erase so they can be used again across sessions.



My Safe Harbor

Draw your calm place. What can you see, hear, and feel there? Where does your Captain's light shine?

My Sea Chest



Draw your strong sea chest. What does the lock look like? Who holds the key?

My Crew and My Stop Signal



Draw your crew. Who is cozy and caring? Who is a strong protector? Who is wise?

My stop signal is: _____

My Wave Meter and My New True Thought



Draw a wave meter from 0 (flat, calm water) to 10 (the biggest storm waves). Color in how big your waves feel today.

My new true thought is: _____

A Note for Grown-Ups

Guidance for parents, caregivers, and clinicians

How to Read This Book

1. Read Parts One and Two many times first. Save Part Three until therapy reaches memory processing.
2. End every reading on a calm page, such as Safe Harbor, Butterfly Hug, or Anchored Inside, never on The Memory Boat Lost at Sea or Triggers pages.
3. Try the calm tools together as you read. Practicing them at calm times makes them easier to use when your child really needs them.
4. The stop signal works during reading too. Your child can close the book anytime.
5. Don't ask what the storm was. The story is kept general on purpose; let your child share only if they choose to.
6. Watch for signs of stress, like fidgeting, going quiet, or asking to skip. Slow down and use a calming tool.
7. Choose the timing. Some kids find bedtime reading cozy; others do better with the storm pages earlier in the day.

What is EMDR?

EMDR (Eye Movement Desensitization and Reprocessing), developed by Francine Shapiro, is a well-researched therapy for trauma and PTSD. The World Health Organization recommends it for children, adolescents, and adults with PTSD. With a trained therapist, a child briefly holds a small piece of a hard memory in mind while using back-and-forth (bilateral) stimulation, such as following the therapist's hand, holding small handheld pulsers, tapping, or hearing alternating tones.

Why memories get stuck.

EMDR is based on the Adaptive Information Processing model. Normally, the brain processes an experience and stores it as something that happened in the past. When an event is overwhelming, that processing can be interrupted. The memory then stays stored with its original images, emotions, body sensations, and beliefs, such as "I'm not safe." Because it isn't linked to later, safer experiences, reminders can set it off as if the danger is happening now.

In the book, the memory boat lost at sea is this unprocessed memory, and Tuff's alarm bell is the protective response. EMDR helps the brain finish processing the memory, so it can be remembered as over without the same distress.

Explaining it at home.

Use the book's words: "When something is really scary, your brain doesn't get to finish putting that memory away. It's like a memory boat that got lost at sea, so sometimes it feels like it's happening again. It's not happening now, and you're safe."

When your child is triggered, you might say: "Those are the stormy feelings coming back. Tuff is ringing the bell. Let's drop our anchors and take a breath together. You're safe right now."

Common signs of trauma stress in children.

Nightmares or trouble sleeping; jumpiness or being easily startled; avoiding reminders, places, or people; sudden big feelings, irritability, or meltdowns; stomachaches and headaches; trouble focusing; clinginess or regression; and repeating the event in play. If you notice these, talk with a qualified professional.

Safety comes first.

EMDR processing is for children who are safe now. If a child is still facing ongoing danger, the first step is making them safe, and preparation focuses on stability and calming skills. This book also speaks to children with more than one memory boat. Repeated or ongoing hard experiences can take more preparation and more time.

If your child shares what happened.

This book never names the storm, and some children feel safe enough to open up while reading it. If that happens, stay calm and keep your voice soft. Believe them, and thank them for telling you. Listen without asking for details; let them share only what they want to. Then let their therapist know. If what they share involves abuse or someone hurting them, contact your local child protective services or law enforcement.

What to expect between EMDR sessions.

Processing keeps working after a session ends. For a day or two, your child may be more tired or emotional, have vivid dreams, or remember new pieces of what happened. This is normal and usually settles quickly. Keep routines steady, offer extra comfort, use the calm tools from the book, and tell the therapist what you notice.

The eight phases of EMDR, and where they appear in this book

Phase	What happens	Where in the book
1. History and treatment planning	The therapist learns the child's story and goals	My Captain through Signs of a Stuck Memory Boat
2. Preparation	Building trust, calming resources, and a stop signal	What Is EMDR? through Butterfly Hug
3. Assessment	Choosing a target memory and noticing the picture, the hard belief, the hoped-for belief, feelings, body sensations, and how big it feels (0–10)	EMDR Helps the Boat Come In
4. Desensitization	Processing with bilateral stimulation	EMDR Helps the Boat Come In; Riding the Waves
5. Installation	Strengthening a helpful belief	The Memory Boat Comes Home
6. Body scan	Checking for leftover body sensations	Done in session (not shown in the story)
7. Closure	Returning to calm at the end of every session	My Sea Chest; My Safe Harbor
8. Reevaluation	Checking in at the next session	Done in session (not shown in the story)

The calming resources in this book

- **Drop My Anchor:** grounding through the feet and the five senses.
- **Safe Harbor:** a calm, safe place the child pictures.
- **Stop Signal:** the child's agreed signal to pause at any time.
- **Sea Chest:** an imagined container that holds upsetting material between sessions.
- **Crew of Helpers:** imagined nurturing, protective, and wise figures, adapted from Resource Development and Installation (Korn and Leeds).
- **Light Stream:** an imagined healing light that soothes body sensations.
- **Butterfly Hug:** crossed arms with alternating taps, developed by Lucina Artigas and Ignacio Jarero.
- **Wave Meter:** a child-friendly version of the 0–10 distress scale (SUD).

Tuff and the Captain.

Tuff represents the brain's alarm system and a protector part, an idea from Internal Family Systems (IFS), developed by Richard Schwartz. Protectors are never bad; they work hard to keep a child safe. The Captain is the Biggest Self: the calm, kind, brave, curious, and wise core that every person has, children and grown-ups alike. Healing invites protectors to rest and trust the Captain, not to leave.

The brain science behind the story.

This is a simplified picture to help families understand; scientists are still learning exactly how the brain heals after trauma. Tuff stays at the lookout; it is the memory that is stuck out at sea. During trauma, the brain's alarm fires hard while its memory-filing system struggles, so the memory is never stamped as past. The alarm keeps spotting that unfiled memory, which is why a reminder today can feel like the danger is happening now.

In the book	In the brain	What it does
Memory boat	Unprocessed trauma memory	Stored in fragments (images, sounds, body feelings, beliefs like "it's my fault") without a "that was then" label
The dock and tying up	Hippocampus and memory consolidation	Files a memory with context and a time stamp, so the brain knows it's over
Tuff at the lookout	Amygdala, the threat detector	Scans for anything that resembles the danger and sounds the alarm
Alarm bell	Stress response	Pounding heart, jumpy body, readiness for danger
The Captain's light	Calm, steady Self, supported by the thinking and calming brain (prefrontal cortex)	Notices, soothes, and leads

In IFS terms, the hurt, frightened feelings out on the memory boat belong to a young, exiled part, and Tuff is the protector keeping watch. EMDR brings the boat home so the hurt can heal and Tuff can finally rest.

What helps, and what doesn't.

Try saying	Try to avoid
"That sounds really scary."	"Just forget about it."
"Your body is trying to protect you."	"That was a long time ago."
"It wasn't your fault."	"You're overreacting."
"I'm right here. You're safe now."	"Stop crying."

You're part of the crew.

Children borrow calm from the grown-ups around them. When you slow your breathing, soften your voice, and stay steady, your child's alarm can settle faster. You don't have to be perfect; repairing after a hard moment matters more than never having one. Your feelings matter too. Caring for a child after trauma is hard, and getting support for yourself is part of helping them heal.

When to get help right away.

Call your child's therapist or doctor soon if symptoms get much worse or last for weeks, if your child stops eating or sleeping, or if they talk about wanting to hurt themselves or someone else. In an emergency, call 911. For a mental health crisis in the U.S., call or text 988, the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline.

Finding an EMDR therapist.

Look for a licensed therapist trained in EMDR, ideally with extra training in working with children. The EMDR International Association (EMDRIA) offers a searchable directory at emdria.org. It's okay to ask how they prepare children before processing and how they involve parents.

Please remember.

This book supports, but is not, treatment. EMDR should be done with a trained, licensed EMDR therapist who prepares your child first, builds calming skills, and lets your child stop anytime. Every child heals at their own pace, and results vary.

About the Author

Jessica Prosser, LPC, is the founder of Anchored Inside Counseling Services in Scottsdale, Arizona, where she helps children, teens, and adults heal from hard experiences. She believes every person has a Captain inside, and that even the biggest storms can grow quiet.

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Tuff is a harbor lookout with one big job: keeping you safe. But when a memory boat gets stuck out at sea, Tuff can't stop ringing the alarm. With a brave crew, a steady anchor, and the Captain's light inside, one child learns how EMDR helps bring the memory boat home.

A gentle, research-informed story for children ages 4–10, with calming tools, drawing pages, and a guide for grown-ups.

Life can be tuff, but so are you.



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